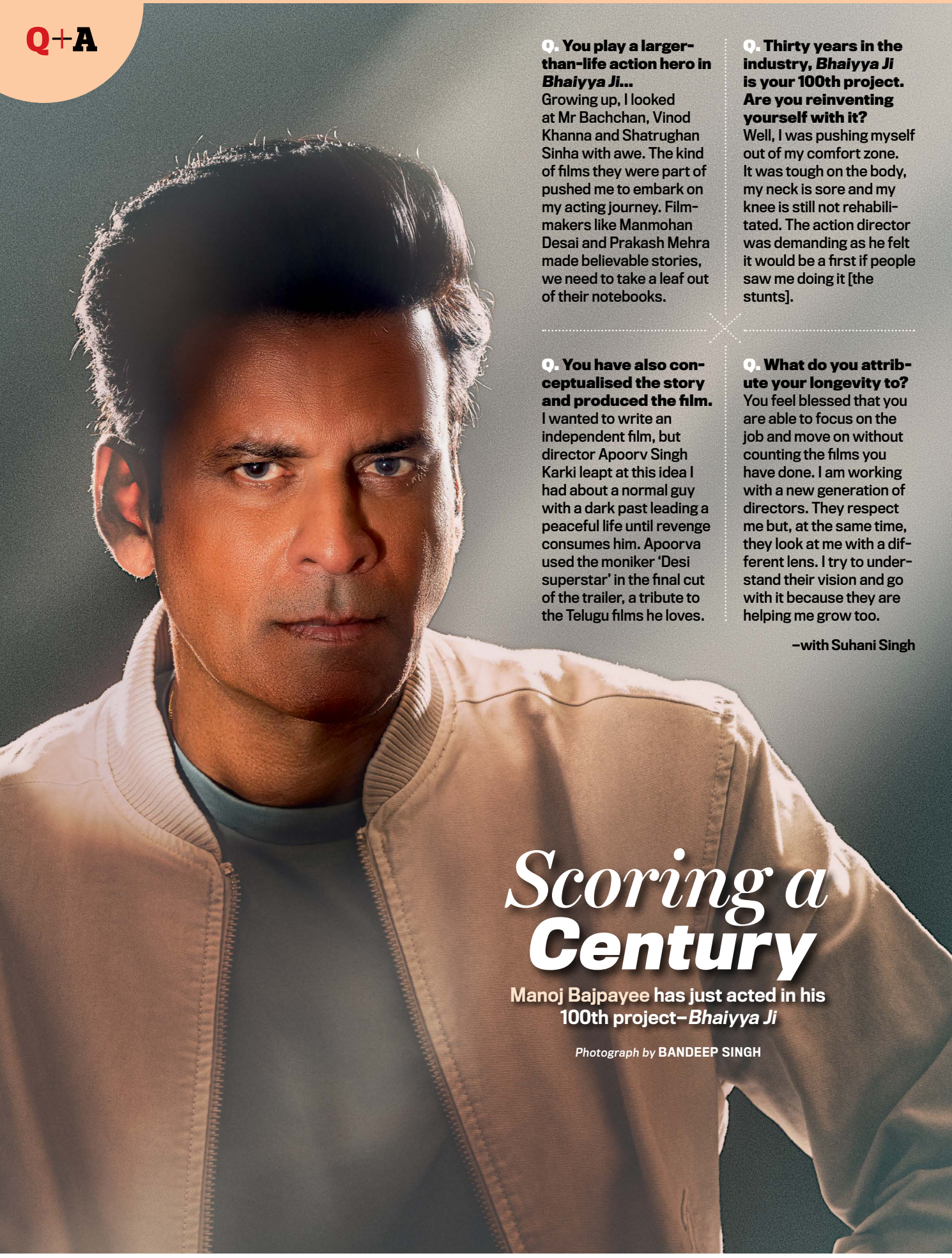


# Scoring a Century

**Manoj Bajpayee has just acted in his 100th project–*Bhaiyya Ji***

*Photograph by* **BANDEEP SINGH**

**Q. You play a larger-than-life action hero in *Bhaiyya Ji*...**
Growing up, I looked at Mr Bachchan, Vinod Khanna and Shatrughan Sinha with awe. The kind of films they were part of pushed me to embark on my acting journey. Filmmakers like Manmohan Desai and Prakash Mehra made believable stories, we need to take a leaf out of their notebooks.

**Q. You have also conceptualised the story and produced the film.**
I wanted to write an independent film, but director Apoorv Singh Karki leapt at this idea I had about a normal guy with a dark past leading a peaceful life until revenge consumes him. Apoorva used the moniker 'Desi superstar' in the final cut of the trailer, a tribute to the Telugu films he loves.

**Q. Thirty years in the industry, *Bhaiyya Ji* is your 100th project. Are you reinventing yourself with it?**
Well, I was pushing myself out of my comfort zone. It was tough on the body, my neck is sore and my knee is still not rehabilitated. The action director was demanding as he felt it would be a first if people saw me doing it [the stunts].

**Q. What do you attribute your longevity to?**
You feel blessed that you are able to focus on the job and move on without counting the films you have done. I am working with a new generation of directors. They respect me but, at the same time, they look at me with a different lens. I try to understand their vision and go with it because they are helping me grow too.

**–with Suhani Singh**